

CAVALRY AND CANNON

THE BATTLE OF MOHACS

In 1526, Sultan Suleyman the Magnificent of the Turkish Ottoman Empire led a powerful army into the territory of King Louis II of Hungary and Bohemia. Meeting Louis' army at Mohacs, Süleyman's forces resisted with skilfully deployed weaponry and traditional fighting skills.

When Suleyman's army marched out of Constantinople on 16 April 1526, its goal was no secret. Expanding his empire in southeastern Europe, Süleyman had already taken the Serbian capital, Belgrade, in 1521. Hungary was the next stepping stone towards his ultimate goal, the Habsburg city of Vienna. King Louis had time to prepare his defences during the Turks' slow progress north. Appeals to other Christian leaders for military aid fell on deaf ears, however, and even the Hungarian nobles who owed Louis allegiance were reluctant to accept his authority.

Through a wet summer that made progress arduous, Suleyman's army advanced along the bank of the Danube, accompanied by a fleet of supply boats. On 14 August they reached the Drava River, a tributary of the Danube that formed Hungary's natural border. Louis' best policy might have been to defend the river crossing here, but the Ottoman forces crossed the rain-swollen flood unmolested. It took them five days to move 300 cannon and an estimated 50,000 to 100,000 men across a skillfully constructed bridge of boats. Louis, meanwhile, awaited the invaders near Mohacs, blocking their road to his capital, Buda.

KNIGHTS AND CANNON

The battle took place on 29 August. Most of Louis' army consisted of armoured knights, although he also had a significant number of cannon. In the tradition of Christian Europe, he intended to gamble on the shock impact of his charging knights to win the day. Suleyman arranged his variegated forces in anticipation of

this. His impressive array of cannon were tied together to form a barrier across the battlefield, reinforced by the Ottomans' elite Janissary infantry armed with arquebuses (small-bore matchlock weapons). In front of this line of gunpowder weapons he placed his own heavy cavalry, the *sipahi*. They were less well armoured than their Christian counterparts, and many were still armed with the composite bow of their Central Asian ancestors. On the flanks, the light irregular horsemen, the *akinji*, awaited the chance to harass, pursue, and plunder. The sultan himself took up position in the rear, surrounded by his household cavalry.

The Hungarians opened the battle by firing their cannon. Then the armoured knights, with King Louis in their midst, thundered forward towards the Ottoman army. Most likely following a prearranged tactical plan, the *sipahi* melted away in front of the knights' onslaught, revealing the line of cannon behind them. As the knights bore down upon the muzzles of the guns, the Ottomans opened fire. Amid a carnage of slaughtered horses and fallen riders the charge was brought to a halt. The Ottoman cavalry then launched a counterattack, and a savage *mêlée* ensued. Meanwhile the *akinji* had stolen around to the Christian rear, and were plundering the camp and massacring the camp followers.

Louis' army disintegrated. The individual survivors sought to escape through woods and swamps, and the king himself died while fleeing – his body was not found for months. Buda was occupied and Hungary became an Ottoman territory.

